could not build up the team. It was always a blame game with us at the receiving end. 'We' had been replaced by 'you'. It was not 'we have made a mistake' but 'you have made a mistake', totally unlike the Army ethos. The Deputy Commandant tried to shield us as much as possible, but the more he shielded us, the more intense became the rivalry between the two. Under such circumstances, we thought better of shifting to Chakrata and applied instead for SF accommodation at Meerut. Since the unit was still at Meerut, at least that support would be forthcoming. Veena requested the school if she could rejoin and the sisters accepted this request straightaway. They had been sad to see Veena leave and were overjoyed at her return. Isha and Amala were among the principal's favourites and it was like returning to the fold. So once again, we were going to have to stay apart, though this time it was our choice.

All the men and women in the SFF are fully para-qualified and proudly wear the para wings on their uniform along with the maroon beret, which is the hallmark of paratroopers the world over. It felt strange not to be para-qualified in an all-para force. In fact, the Commandant was firmly of the opinion that all officers coming on deputation must volunteer and qualify as soon as possible on reporting to the SFF. Many would not, and this would instantaneously put them in the bad books of the Commandant. The airborne training was conducted at the Para Training School (PTS) at Sarsawa, and that is where David, Ajay and I reported, having volunteered for it as much to qualify, as to get away from the shenanigans of the Commandant for six weeks. Jumping out of a plane was better than bearing with the Commandant.

The six weeks of training were tough. We were generally fit but not at the levels required for paratrooper training. The first few days were almost entirely spent on regaining peak

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